Medha is thoughtful, efficient and empathetic; her MBE for services to cricket was widely celebrated.

Another long-term member of the support team, Phil Neale, makes sure everything runs smoothly. He has been the England team's operations manager since 1999, and utilizes a huge range of experience, as the last of the old-time footballer-cricketers. He played 358 matches for Lincoln City and 354 first-class games for Worcestershire, where he was captain for ten years before moving into coaching. He is as likely to be found helping slip practice as organizing our bags.

The old grind of airport–hotel–ground–hotel–airport had been minimized by modern performance planning, but eventually in a sport like ours, resilience wears thin. I was going through the motions of stretching, lying on the outfield in Christchurch midway through the second Test during the subsequent series in New Zealand in March 2018 when I unburdened myself to Chris Silverwood, England's bowling coach. We were at ease in each other's company, having just shared Essex's title win in the County Championship.

I had scored twenty-three runs in my four Test innings in a losing series and was thinking beyond a match we were destined to draw. 'I'm done with it,' I told him. He didn't seem desperately surprised, but urged caution: 'Look, whatever you do don't say anything. Obviously, you've had a tough tour and a tough winter. Just get through the next two days, then go home and see how you feel.'

I had begun to dread net sessions. I had always found them hard work throughout my England career and disliked their imperfections. Everyone oversteps the mark, bowling from seventeen or eighteen yards, no matter how stringent the bowling coach. They'd argue it was irrelevant, since they didn't bowl no-balls when it mattered, but it was a constant source of irritation.

There is a time for experimentation in the nets, but I hated the embarrassment of getting out. I never wanted to give my wicket away, whatever the circumstances. When I allowed myself to be more proactive, I would try new things away from prying eyes, in a private session with our batting coach, Graham Gooch. Seeing people showboat, trying to sweep flashily or hit every ball over the top, used to get to me.

Nets can be subtly confrontational. I can't lie – I used to love it when I got Jimmy Anderson or Stuart Broad. I knew Jimmy would be bowling at